

# Raptor Rehabilitation Center Is For The Birds

The bird's big dark eyes blinked slowly as Mathias Englemann gently pulled him out of the sky kennel, a plastic cage usually used to transport pets on airplanes.

The barred owl was brought to the Carolina Raptor Center and Englemann's care after it was hit by a car in Troutman. As he cradled the injured owl in one arm, Englemann gently opened the bird's beak and gave it some medication. Pat Marcum, executive director, said that he could name the bird. He named the barred owl Norman.

Norman, with his concussion and damage to his left eye, is just one example of the raptors at the center. The Carolina Raptor Center, Inc., is a nonprofit corporation dedicated to the rehabilitation, research, reproduction and conservation of birds of prey and to the education of the public about those birds.

The center is located in Latta Plantation Park on Mountain Island Lake between Lake Norman and Charlotte.

The Raptor Center occupies some 58 acres in the 760 acre preserve.

Englemann is a dedicated volunteer who spends 50 to 60 hours a week coordinating rehabilitation of the raptors. Sylvia Larson is a rehabilitation technician who is also a full time volunteer.

The idea of the Raptor Center started in a basement at the University of North Carolina at Charlotte with Dr. Richard Brown, who now heads the Carolina Raptor Center Foundation, Inc. The center was founded in October of 1980 and incorporated in December of 1981. Mecklenburg County contributed



Center Rehabilitation Coordinator Mathias Englemann cradles Norman, an injured owl. Photos/Ann Wick

funds to the center last year, according to Marcum, for hiring of staff.

The local facility is one of seven regional centers for the National Raptor Rehabilitation Association. Over 900 injured and orphaned birds of prey have been brought to the center over the years by the concerned public. Over 40 percent recover to be released to the wild.

Disabled birds are used for breeding programs and education programs.

The three most common raptors brought to the center are red-tailed hawks, barred owls and great horned owls.

Some of the permanently disabled birds are on display in habitats along the nature trail at the center. As part of its educational efforts, the Rap

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Center now opens to the public on Saturdays and Sundays from noon until 5 pm. Admission is free but donations are needed. Special group tours can be arranged for a minimal charge.

Birds to be seen along the nature trail include Queen Charlotte, a bald eagle, and Lottie, a golden eagle. There are also vultures, owls, hawks to be seen along the way.

"We are constantly enlarging the nature trail," Marcum noted. "These are birds people never have a chance to see in their whole life. Here you can see them up close. You can see what powerful, magnificent creatures they are and realize they have a right to live, too."

Marcum and center volunteers travel around the country to give programs on raptors, also as part of their continuing efforts to educate the public.

What can you do if you find an injured bird of prey? Marcum says one of the most frustrating things is that people will sometimes try to care for an injured bird themselves.

"By the time we get it, it is malnourished," Marcum explained. "Birds don't show hunger or pain and they are usually in shock. If it was an injured person, you wouldn't get to get them to a doctor."

It is best to get the bird off the road or out of the way of other danger immediately. The best way to do this, Marcum explained, is to cover the bird with a towel or blanket, smoothing the wing feathers back from behind.

"They calm down in the dark," she continued. The next step is to get the bird into a cardboard box (make sure there are some air holes) with a lid for easier transportation to the Carolina Raptor Center. You can remove the blanket or towel once the bird is



An owl named Dumbo assists with the educational programs at the Raptor Center.

in the box. When people call about birds and they can't bring them in, the center usually finds a volunteer to go and get the bird. "We get calls from all over North Carolina and even outside the state," Marcum noted.

Another particular frustration for Marcum and the other volunteers occurs often when well meaning people find baby owls they think are abandoned. What actually happens is the owls are in a stage of life where they have left the nest but are still being cared for by their parents. At this stage, owl behavior is imprinted on them from their parents so they can function in the wild. If a human begins to care for the bird, the bird becomes imprinted as a human.

"The poor bird thinks it's a human. It can never live a normal social life in the wild. It may be perfectly healthy but it's non-releasable," she said.

People also need to be aware that it is against both Federal and state laws to injure or possess a bird of prey. An injured bird needs to be turned over to a licensed rehabilitator. Most veterinarians have neither the facilities, the time nor the experience to handle these birds.

The Raptor Center has a speakers bureau. "We did 468 programs last year," Marcum said proudly. When they attend shows like the Piedmont Sportsman and RV Show in Winston-Salem, they take the gift

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shop with them as well as birds. The gift shop offers various items such as Bird of Prey kites and handmade bald eagle boat flags.

In addition to the ongoing educational program and the rehabilitation program, the center is committed to research and breeding programs to learn more about the endangered species in particular.

The Carolina Raptor Center is currently housed in two mobile units. They are hoping for the donation of a double wide trailer to house the intensive care facility. Plans for the future include a capital fundraising project for a permanent building. This facility would accommodate a museum, gift shop, auditorium for educational programs, research and rehabilitation facilities.

For information about Carolina Raptor Center memberships, write to PO Box 16443, Charlotte NC 28297-6443 or call 875-6521.

To call the center to report an injured bird, call 1-800-CAR-HAWK or 1-800-CALL-OWL.

By Ann Wicker



Lottie, a golden eagle, can be seen at the Raptor Center.

Photo/Ann Wicker

## Wildlife Orphanage Continues Work

The Lincoln Wildlife Orphanage began its eighth year in 1987 and continues to offer education and rehabilitation resources for the area. Located near Lake Norman in Lincoln County, the Lincoln Wildlife Orphanage was founded by Sonja Hootman and her husband, James.

In 1986, with funds from a state grant, they built an orphaned fawn care facility. Seven fawns were taken in by the new facility.

During 1986, the orphanage took in 254 different animals, from rabbits to doves to one Great Blue Heron.

The Lincoln Wildlife Orphanage is always looking for sponsors and contributors. Sonja Hootman conducts workshops and programs throughout the year for schools and organizations. If you are interested in arranging a program or helping, contact the orphanage at 735-0790.

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